Carry on turning

Experiments in turning plywood

I have spent some more time with my family recently and also managed a bit of DIY, though there are still plenty of items on the 'to do' list. However, I have made a good start to the New Year's resolutions I mentioned some time back. I am currently updating a book I wrote a while ago: it is amazing how much has changed in the 10 years or so since I wrote the book. Anyway, it means that almost every night now is spent trying to get that done to meet the submission deadline. As with all things, a compromise must be achieved. I have mentioned before that my life is mapped out by places to be at certain times and deadlines, with life happening in between all of these commitments.

I am mindful of the ever-increasing comments from turners about these compromises happening to them too. Many people are retiring later in life or are working part time instead of retiring.

Whether working or not, it seems people are doing far more for their families than their parents did for them. All say it is a sign of ever changing times: earning money, baby sitting, child minding, school runs and DIY take up a large part of their time. Hobbies such as turning, have to fit in between everything else. That said, there seems to be an ever more diverse amount of things created on the lathe and partially on the lathe. I love the fact that people are enjoying turning and making what they choose rather than following preconceived ideas of what turning is. I admire the beauty of working with wood; its wonderful tactile quality, how versatile it is, the natural colours and the ability of some to be coloured in various ways. I also love the fact that it is so unlike any other material. I am inspired by the people who are always pushing boundaries so that we are seeing new things.

While some turners are developing new shapes and applying novel techniques to their work, there are others who find joy in creating beautiful items on the lathe with nothing more than sanding and the application of finish to enhance them. I really enjoy the fact that there are some who have found great challenges and love problem solving when they turn. Look at segmented turners: the mathematical problem solving for some of the shapes involved and the precision required provides wonderful personal challenges. Then also consider the delightful sculptural work produced using a variety of methods. There are a lot of things people can do to work with wood, using turning as the core focal point and all provide challenges a plenty. Please, in the daily mêlée of life, don't forget the fun to be had and remind yourself to make some time for turning. Even if you can only spend a short time in the workshop during the week, it is well worth it. Let me know what you have been making.

Regards,
Mark

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Woodworkers Institute website (**www.woodworkersinstitute.com**) is thriving. It would be great if you took a look and participated in the various discussions and competitions in our community, or see us on Facebook & Twitter.

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